‘You Think You Just Fell Out of a Coconut Tree?’[1]: Rethinking Fascism in Franco’s Spain

By

Taryn Cail

Prof. Dr. Cheryl Fury HIST 4106

Fall 2026

[1] Kamala Harris, “Remarks at the Swearing-In Ceremony of Commissioners for the White House Initiative on Advancing Educational Equity, Excellence, and Economic Opportunity for Hispanics,” May 10, 2023, video, The White House, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rNIvR1wqYu8.

Kamala Harris's now-famous remark, “You think you just fell out of a coconut tree?”,[2] takes on an unintended historical irony when considered alongside contemporary debates about authoritarianism and fascism in American politics. As Harris continued, “You exist in the context of all in which you live and what came before you.” Her observation also raises a question central to the historical study of fascism: can a political regime be adequately understood without examining the circumstances that produced it? This question is particularly relevant to Spain under Francisco Franco, whose political character has long challenged conventional definitions of European fascism. Although Franco’s regime adopted characteristics commonly associated with fascism including hyper nationalism, political violence, a single-party system, and authoritarian leadership, historians have disagreed over whether these features were sufficient to consider the dictatorship genuinely fascist because of its continued reliance on traditional institutions that were not typically associated with fascist ideology. Unlike Nazi Germany or Fascist Italy, Franco’s Spain created a relationship with traditional Catholic and military institutions. These distinctions have encouraged historians to describe Francoism as authoritarian or fascitized rather than fully fascist.[3] However, such distinctions raise a broader question about how fascism itself should be understood. Rather than excluding Francoism from the broader history of European fascism because of its differences, Francoism itself demonstrates the need

---

[2] Harris, “Remarks at the Swearing-In Ceremony.”
[3] Ismael Saz Campos, “Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism in Franco’s Dictatorship,” Social History 29, no. 3 (2004): 345.

for a more flexible understanding of fascism that accounts for its development within distinct contexts. If fascism developed differently across European societies, should every regime be expected to reproduce the political structures of Germany or Italy to qualify as fascist? This essay argues that Franco's Spain, particularly during the Civil War and the early years of his dictatorship, should be understood as a distinct form of fascism rather than simply an authoritarian dictatorship that borrowed fascist characteristics.

Examining the political divisions that preceded the Spanish Civil War (1936-39) are essential to understanding how Francoism emerged as a distinct form of fascism shaped by Spain's particular history. During the spring and early summer of 1936, Spain experienced increasing tensions between competing political, religious and economic interests. Strikes, confrontations between left-wing and right-wing organizations, attacks on churches, and disputes over land ownership contributed to an atmosphere of instability.[4] Political loyalties were often shaped by religious beliefs, economic class, political ideology, occupation, and family history.[5] These tensions were brought on by years of unrest and as the conflict intensified, these divides increasingly separated communities, families and individuals, forcing many Spaniards to pick a side.[6] The outbreak of the Spanish Civil War transformed Spain's existing political divisions into a struggle for national power, creating the conditions in which Franco's dictatorship and its fascist influences would develop. The uprising spread to mainland Spain, developing into a civil war between the Republican government and the Nationalist forces.[7] The Nationalist movement brought together military officers, monarchists, Falangists, Carlists, and Catholic supporters,

---

[4] William D. Phillips Jr. and Carla Rahn Phillips, A Concise History of Spain (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 252.
[5] Ibid., 253.
[6] Ibid., 253-4.
[7] William D. Phillips Jr. and Carla Rahn Phillips, A Concise History of Spain (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 253.

creating a coalition, despite their differences, united in opposition of the Republic.[8] Fransico Franco emerged as the leading figure within this movement and assumed power as head of the Nationalist state on October 1, 1936. His appointment was supported by an alliance of monarchists and military figures who sought to establish a unified Nationalist leadership.[9] Franco also received military assistance from Mussolini's Fascist Italy, which sent thousands of soldiers to support the Nationalist forces in 1937.[10]As the war progressed, Nationalist forces expanded their control over Spain. Following military campaigns throughout 1937 and 1938, they conquered Catalonia in early 1939 and entered Madrid at the end of March. The Nationalist victory was consolidated in April 1939, establishing Franco's dictatorship over Spain.[11]

The combination of fascist ideology and traditional institutions within Franco's dictatorship demonstrates why fascism must be understood as a political phenomenon capable of taking different forms across different national contexts. Fascism is generally associated with ultranationalism, opposition to liberalism and communism, authoritarian leadership, mass mobilization, and political violence.[12] Fascist movements also frequently promoted narratives of national victimhood, portraying the nation as weakened or threatened by internal and external enemies. Within this framework, political violence could be justified as a means of national purification and regeneration, aimed at eliminating perceived threats and restoring national unity.[13] However, fascist movements did not necessarily share identical political structures or objectives. Stanley Payne argues that the characteristics commonly associated with fascism should be understood as a comparative framework rather than a rigid definition, recognizing that

---

[8] Rodrigo, "Fascism and Violence in Spain,", 6.
[9] Stanley G. Payne, Fascism in Spain, 1923–1977 (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1999), 241.
[10] Phillips and Phillips, A Concise History of Spain, 255.
[11] Ibid., 256-7.
[12] Stanley G. Payne, Fascism: Comparison and Definition (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1980), 5–9.
[13] Robert O. Paxton, "The Five Stages of Fascism," Journal of Modern History 70, no. 1 (1998): 6-7.

fascist movements differed considerably across national contexts.[14] While authoritarianism emphasizes concentrated political authority and traditional conservatism seeks to preserve established institutions, fascism is distinguished by its emphasis on national regeneration, collective identity, and political mobilization. The difficulty of defining fascism also involves determining whether it should be understood primarily as an ideology or through its political practices. Fascist ideology emphasized national unity, collective identity, and the regeneration of a supposedly weakened nation. Roger Eatwell identifies the pursuit of national rebirth and a radical alternative to existing political systems as a central feature of fascist ideology.[15] However, the political practice is equally important. Fascist movements often adapted to their circumstances, particularly when attempting to gain or maintain power. Robert Paxton argues that fascist regimes frequently governed alongside traditional elites, including military leaders, religious institutions, and conservative economic interests, creating a struggle for influence between the political leader, fascist party, state officials, and established institutions.[16] Rather than determining whether a regime was fascist solely by measuring its similarities to Nazi Germany or Fascist Italy, fascism should be examined within the specific political and historical circumstances in which it developed. This approach allows for the recognition of distinct national forms of fascism without disregarding the ideological characteristics they shared. This distinction is particularly relevant to Franco's Spain, where the influence of fascist ideology on political institutions, leadership, and violence must be considered alongside the continued importance of established Catholic and military institutions.

---

[14] Payne, Fascism: Comparison and Definition, 5–9.
[15] Roger Eatwell, "On Defining the 'Fascist Minimum': The Centrality of Ideology," Journal of Political Ideologies 1, no. 3 (1996): 304–5.
[16] Robert O. Paxton, "The Five Stages of Fascism," Journal of Modern History 70, no. 1 (1998): 17–18.

Fascist political ideology is exemplified in Franco's regime in a few different ways. Firstly, the influence of Italian fascism on Franco's emerging dictatorship demonstrates that fascism was not merely a superficial characteristic of the Nationalist movement, but an important influence on its political development. Beyond the military assistance provided during the Civil War, Italian involvement also extended into political and ideological matters, as Mussolini encouraged the development of fascist institutions within the emerging Nationalist state.[17] Javier Rodrigo describes this process of fascitization as an intentional effort to influence the organization and political direction of Franco's emerging regime.[18] Italian influence was visible in the Nationalist's adoption of fascist propaganda and symbolism. Rodrigo documents requests for photographs of Mussolini, propaganda images, and films produced by the Italian Istituto Luce.[19] Fascist symbols, including the Roman salute, Falange blue shirts, and the yoke and arrows, became increasingly prominent within the Nationalist movement.[20] Franco also adopted the title *Caudillo*, like the Italian *Duce* and German *Fuhrer,* emphasized the authority of a single national leader and reinforced the personalization of political power. [21] Although symbolism alone cannot determine whether a regime was fascist, the widespread adoption of these symbols demonstrates how fascist political culture became increasingly integrated into the Nationalist movement, helping establish a shared political identity that associated Franco's emerging dictatorship with the broader European fascist movement.

Secondly, Franco's emphasis on authoritarian leadership, national unity, and political hierarchy further demonstrates how fascist principles influenced the ideological foundations of

---

[17] Javier Rodrigo, "On Fascistization: Mussolini's Political Project for Franco's Spain, 1937–1939," Journal of Modern Italian Studies 22, no. 4 (2017): 471.
[18] Rodrigo, "On Fascistization," 471.
[19] Ibid., 473.
[20] Rodrigo, "On Fascistization,", 474.
[21] Stanley G. Payne, The Franco Regime, 1936–1975 (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1987), 117.

his dictatorship. Upon assuming power, he promoted a political system based on authority, hierarchy, and national unity. While these principles were not exclusive to fascism, their combination with fascist ideas of national regeneration and collective identity reflected the broader ideological influence of fascism on Franco's emerging dictatorship. These developments suggest that fascism was not merely an external influence adopted for appearances. Rather, these practices reflected fascist ideas of collective national identity and political mobilization, extending beyond the concentration of power in a single leader to include efforts to organize society around a unified political movement. However, the influence of fascism extended beyond Franco's conception of leadership and into the organization of his emerging dictatorship.

Thirdly, the incorporation of the Falange into the Francoist state demonstrates how fascist ideology developed into political institutions that extended its influence throughout Spanish society. In April 1937, Franco unified the Falange with the Carlist Traditionalists, creating the Falange Espanola Traditionalista y de las JONS (FET y de las JONS).[22] This organization brought different Nationalist factions under Franco's leadership while establishing a unified political movement incorporating important elements of Spanish fascism, particularly its emphasis on nationalist unity, political mobilization, and the organization of society through party-controlled institutions.[23] The Falange subsequently exercised considerable influence over political propaganda, youth groups, women's organizations, and trade unions. This involvement allowed the Falange to promote the regime's political ideas across different sections of Spanish society. Through its influence over youth groups and trade unions, the Falange could shape political participation and reinforce the regime's ideology across different sections of society.[24]

---

[22] Phillips and Phillips, A Concise History of Spain, 258.
[23] Saz Campos, "Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism," 347.
[24] Ibid., 347.

This demonstrates how fascist political practices became embedded within Franco's dictatorship rather than remaining merely symbolic, extending fascist influence beyond symbol displays into everyday Spanish society.[25]

Fourthly, the ideological role of political violence in Franco's dictatorship further supports its classification as a distinct form of fascism, particularly through its connection to national purification and political unity. Although repression was not exclusive to fascist governments, fascist violence frequently served ideological purposes beyond eliminating political opposition. Rather than functioning solely as a means of maintaining political authority, fascist violence could also serve as a means of national purification, political mobilization, and the creation of a unified collective identity. Javier Rodrigo identifies violence as a fundamental component of fascist political culture, arguing that it contributed to the creation of political solidarity, the identification of internal enemies and the public demonstration of political power.[26] Nationalist repression during the Spanish Civil War demonstrates how political violence became an instrument for enforcing a particular vision of Spanish national identity rather than simply eliminating political opposition. Nationalist repression involved imprisonment, intimidation, humiliation, execution and ideological reeducation. These practices were directed against individuals and groups identified as enemies of the Nationalist cause, including Republicans, communists, socialists and other left-wing political movements. The Nationalists portrayed the suppression of these groups as necessary to restore national order.[27] Falangist violence against left-wing political opponents during the Civil War reflected this idea of political cleansing, as the removal of perceived enemies was presented as necessary to restore national

---

[25] Saz Campos, “Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism,” 347.
[26] Rodrigo, “Fascism and Violence in Spain,” 3-5.
[27] Ibid., 5-7.

unity.[28] Such an interpretation closely corresponds with Paxton's identification of national victimhood, collective identity, and the legitimization of violence against perceived enemies as recurring characteristics of fascism.[29] The relationship between violence and national regeneration is central to understanding Francoism as fascist. The Nationalist movement sought to construct a unified political community through the identification and removal of those considered incompatible with its vision of Spain. While political violence alone cannot establish that a regime was fascist, its connection to ultranationalism, political cleansing, and the transformation of society demonstrates substantial indications of fascism. Though these political practices were in line with a traditional view of fascism, there are other aspects of Franco's regime which differed from typical manifestations of fascism

Franco's dependence on the Catholic Church, military leadership, and conservative elites presents the strongest challenge to classifying his dictatorship as fascist, raising the question of whether fascism could coexist with traditional institutions. Although cooperation with traditional institutions was not unique to Francoism, the continued importance of the Catholic Church, military leadership, and conservative elites shaped the particular form fascism took within Franco's dictatorship. These characteristics contributed to Juan Linz's classification of Francoism as an authoritarian rather than a totalitarian regime.[30] Ismael Saz develops this distinction through the concept of a fascitized dictatorship. He argues that Francoism adopted fascist institutions, political methods, and organizations of social control but that the fascist movement remained a subordinated tool to the state. Consequently, the regime could not be considered "fully fascist", although it was also not free from fascist influence.[31] The unification of the

[28] Rodrigo, "Fascism and Violence in Spain," 8.
[29] Paxton, "The Five Stages of Fascism," 6-7.
[30] Phillips and Phillips, A Concise History of Spain, 263-4.
[31] Saz Campos, "Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism," 345.

Falange in 1937 illustrates this argument, the creation of FET y de las JONS established a powerful political organization with fascist characteristics separate from Franco's dictatorship.[32] Similarly, the Catholic Church also retained considerable influence, particularly over education.[33]Although Francoism retained these powerful traditional institutions rather than consolidating them under his power, their continued influence does not necessarily contradict its fascist character. Paxton argues that fascist regimes historically governed through relationships with established elites rather than exercising complete independence from them. He identifies struggles for influence among the political leader, fascist party, state institutions, and traditional elites as characteristics of a fascist government.[34] Furthermore, Catholicism was not necessarily incompatible with Spanish fascist ideology. Rodrigo observes that Spanish fascists identified as Catholics and incorporated religion into their understanding of national identity.[35] However, if fascism is understood as a political phenomenon, Franco's reliance on Catholic traditions, military leadership, and conservative institutions does not necessarily discount his dictatorship from the broader category of fascism; it merely shows its distinct formation.

Francoism's transformation following the Second World War muddies its classification as fascist, but the regime's changing political identity does not necessarily diminish the importance of fascism during its formation. Following the defeat of the Axis powers, Franco reduced the prominence of fascist symbolism and increasingly emphasized the regimes catholic, conservative, and anti-communist identity.[36] Guy Hermet argues that Francoism's political character changed over time, with National Catholicism and later economic development

---

[32] Saz Campos, "Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism," 347.
[33] Ibid., 347.
[34] Paxton, "The Five Stages of Fascism," 17–18.
[35] Rodrigo, "Fascism and Violence in Spain," 8.
[36] Guy Hermet, "Spain under Franco: The Changing Character of an Authoritarian Regime," European Journal of Political Research 4, no. 3 (1976): 321.

becoming increasingly important to the regime's legitimacy.[37] These developments suggest that Franco's primary objectives were the preservation of political authority rather than a consistent commitment to fascist ideology. However, the regime's transformation does not necessarily mean that its earlier fascist characteristics were superficial. Rodrigo challenges the interpretation that fascism in Spain simply disappeared after 1945, emphasizing that the fascist political organizations, social practices and conceptions of national identity had already influenced the development of the dictatorship.[38] Paxton's understanding of fascism as a changing political process provides a useful framework for interpreting this development. Fascist regimes could evolve through different stages, potentially moving towards radicalization or decline depending on their political circumstances.[39] Francoism's postwar transformation therefore complicates its classification, but it does not erase the significance of fascism during the Civil War and early dictatorship. Instead, these periods of time should be treated as distinct versions of its interpretation of fascism depending on its national and political context.

Franco's Spain demonstrates that the presence of traditional authoritarian institutions does not necessarily exclude a dictatorship from the broader category of fascism, particularly when its ideology, political organizations, and methods of repression reveal substantial fascist influences. Franco's control over the Falange, his dependence on the Catholic church and military and the regime's transformation after the Second World War distinguish it from other European fascist movements. However, these differences do not necessarily exclude Francoism from the broader history of fascism. The incorporation of fascist political organizations, the promotion of ultranationalist unity, and the central role of political violence demonstrates that fascism was

[37] Guy Hermet, "Spain under Franco", 321.
[38] Rodrigo, "Fascism and Violence in Spain," 9-10.
[39] Paxton, "The Five Stages of Fascism," 20.

more than a superficial influence on Franco's emerging dictatorship. Ultimately, Franco's Spain demonstrates why fascism should be understood through the interaction of ideology, institutions, political violence, and historical development rather than a rigid set of requirements. Its Catholic traditions and military leadership were not simply deviations from a supposedly universal model of fascism, but part of the historical circumstances through which Spanish fascism developed. Francoism cannot be understood independently of political divisions, ideological influence and traditional institutions that shaped its emergence. To return to the question originally posed, can a political regime truly be understood without considering the historical context in which it emerges? Or, as Kamala Harris might ask, "You think you just fell out of a coconut tree?"[40]

[40] Harris, "Remarks at the Swearing-In Ceremony."

Bibliography

Eatwell, Roger. “On Defining the `Fascist Minimum’: The Centrality of Ideology.” Journal of Political Ideologies 1, no. 3 (1996), 303-19.

Harris, Kamala. “Remarks at the Swearing-In Ceremony of Commissioners for the White House Initiative on Advancing Educational Equity, Excellence, and Economic Opportunity for Hispanics.” May 10, 2023. Video. The White House. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rNIvR1wqYu8.

Hermet, Guy. “Spain under Franco: The Changing Character of an Authoritarian Regime.”. European Journal of Political Research 4, no. 3 (1976), 311–27.

Ismael Saz Campos. “Fascism, Fascistization and Developmentalism in Franco’s Dictatorship.”. Social History 29, no. 3 (2004), 342–57.

Payne, Stanley G. The Franco Regime, 1936-1975. Madison, Wisconsin: University of Wisconsin Press, 1987

Payne, Stanley G. Fascism: Comparison and Definition. Madison, Wisconsin: University of Wisconsin Press, 1980.

Payne, Stanley G. Fascism in Spain, 1923-1977. Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1999.

Paxton, Robert O. “The Five Stages of Fascism.” Journal of Modern History 70, no. 1 (1998) 1-19.

Phillips, William D., and Carla Rahn Phillips. A Concise History of Spain. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010.

Rodrigo, Javier. “Fascism and Violence in Spain: A Comparative Update.” International Journal of Iberian Studies 25, no. 3 (2013), 183–99.

Rodrigo, Javier. “On Fascistization: Mussolini’s Political Project for Franco’s Spain, 1937–1939.”. Journal of Modern Italian Studies 22, no. 4 (2017), 469–87.